the late eighth century CE, that a youthful South Indian sage rose to heal and rejuvenate a divided religion.

ADI SHANKARA

This was Adi Shankara, whose Advaita Vedanta was the philosophically robust response to that era of confusion, integrating diverse thoughts and Hindu practices into a philosophy based on the Vedic dictum of 'One Truth, Many Expositions'. Advaita Vedanta is only one—and arguably the last—of the six schools known as the 'six systems' (Shad Darshanas) of mainstream Hindu philosophy, but it has proved the most enduring. Shankara emphasised the importance of *pramanas* or methods of reasoning, tempered by *anubhava* or intuitive experience, which empower the seeker to gain the spiritual knowledge adumbrated by the sacred texts. He focused on selected texts—the Bhagavad Gita, the Brahma Sutras and ten of the 108 *Upanishad*s—as the key reference works of Hindu *dharma*, illuminating them through his *bhashyas* (commentaries). Reasoning is essential to clarify the truth, according to the Advaita School, and Shankara was a famous debater of his time, challenging and being challenged by those of different philosophical persuasions but triumphing always through the power of his reasoning and the force of his arguments. His *bhashya*s are all written in prose, not verse, with lucidity and sharpness, and employ the Upanishadic question-and-answer format that the West calls 'Socratic'.

Adi Shankara also authored the *Vivekachudamani*, 581 verses spelling out the qualifications required in a student of Vedanta: to be able to discriminate between the real and the unreal; to be able to maintain a spirit of detachment from this world; to have the capacity to control sensory perceptions; and to feel an intense desire to attain self-realisation and *moksha*. The *Vivekachudamani* reviews the entire range of Hindu philosophical thought and argument, from the *Upanishad*s to the Bhagavad Gita. More accessibly, and as part of his effort to popularise the faith, Adi Shankara also authored a hundred *stotrams*, verses that can be sung as *bhajan*s by the worshipper (or *bhakt*)—many fairly brief but some quite long, like his most famous *bhajan*, the Bhaja Govindam. Most of the *stotrams* (hymns or verses) relate to the worship of the major